explAIn

Context engineering

Treat the context like an API contract: every part needs an owner and a trust level.

"Construct the world the model reasons inside."

Ask on every project

1. What exactly does the model receive on one request, in order? Can we log it?
2. Who owns each part of the context, and when was it last reviewed?
3. Which parts can a user, an email, a web page or a tool result write into?
4. If injected text took control, what is the worst the system would let it do?
5. What gets trimmed, summarized or dropped when the window fills up?

Rules of thumb

- Fix a conflicting instruction at its source; never add a rule to overrule another.
- Label untrusted content with its source and pass it as data, never as instructions.
- Vary few-shot examples and include an edge case; the model copies their flaws too.
- Cap what a hijacked model can do: least-privilege tools, approval for sends and deletes.

Red flags

- ⚠ Nobody can say who owns the system prompt
- ⚠ The prompt grows by one rule per incident and nothing is ever removed
- ⚠ Retrieved text or tool output pasted in raw, with no labels or delimiters
- ⚠ One flow mixes private data, untrusted content and a way to send data out

Key terms

Data leakage	Private data reaching a prompt, a log or a reply that should not hold it.
System instructions	Your team's role, rules and format, re-sent every call; weighted higher, not enforced.
Few-shot examples	Sample inputs and outputs in the context that the model copies closely.
Context pollution	Stale, conflicting or irrelevant text that distracts or misleads the model.
Indirect injection	Instructions hidden in content the model reads, like an email, page or tool result.

TEMPLATE

Context assembly template

Role and rules: purpose, hard limits and tone; one owner, no conflicts, stable so it caches

Examples: a few varied input and output pairs in the target format, including an edge case

Reference material: only relevant chunks, delimited, labeled with source and date, as data

Tool results: the fields the task needs, not raw dumps, labeled with the system they came from

History: recent turns that still matter; older ones summarized or dropped

Task and output format: the current question restated, plus the schema or format required